

Bandit - Level 01

Goal

The password for the next level is stored in a file called `-` in the home directory of `bandit1`.

Connection

```
ssh -p 2220 bandit1@bandit.labs.overthewire.org
```

Use the password retrieved at the end of [Bandit - Level 00](#).

Concepts

This level is pure shell syntax, not exploitation — the kind of thing where, as you put it, "either you know it or you don't." Full conceptual breakdown lives in [Linux - Argument Parsing and Special Filenames](#); the short version:

A file named exactly `-` collides with a long-standing Unix convention: a bare `-` argument means "read from stdin" to many tools, `cat` included. So the naive `cat -` doesn't error — it just hangs, waiting for keyboard input, because it's reading from your terminal instead of opening the file.

Solution Approach

Two of the three standard techniques resolved this cleanly; the third revealed a real exception worth knowing:

```
cat ./-          # ✓ works - explicit relative path
cat /home/bandit1/- # ✓ works - explicit absolute path
cat -- -         # ✗ hangs - see note below
```

`cat -- -` did **not** work as expected — it hung waiting for keyboard input instead of printing the file. This isn't a mistake, it's a genuine quirk: `--` isn't honored identically by every tool, and `cat` specifically still treats a bare `-` as "read from stdin" even after `--`. The explicit path (`./-` or the absolute path) is the technique that actually works for a file named *exactly* `-`. Full explanation, now corrected with this finding: [Linux - Argument Parsing and Special Filenames](#).

Points of Friction

- Tried `cat /home/bandit1/- .txt` first, assuming the file might have an extension — it doesn't; the filename is literally just `-`, nothing appended.
- `cat -- -` hung (had to `Ctrl+C` out) instead of erroring or working — confirmed `--` doesn't override `cat`'s bare-dash-means-stdin convention. Documented as a correction to the general note, since the original draft assumed `--` would work universally.

Key Takeaway

Quoting the filename (`cat "--"`) would *not* have worked — that's a common trap. Quotes only stop the shell from doing word-splitting/globbing; they don't change what `cat` itself sees once it receives the argument. The fix has to be `--` , a relative path, or an absolute path — see the linked note for why.

Next

```
ssh -p 2220 bandit2@bandit.labs.overthewire.org
```

 using the password found above.

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